

# Tide print advert

## (1950's)

### AS Component 1: Investigating the Media A level Component 1: Media Products, Industries and Audiences

#### Focus areas: Media language Representation Audiences Media contexts

#### PRODUCT CONTEXT

- Designed specifically for heavy-duty, machine cleaning, Procter & Gamble launched *Tide* in 1946 and it quickly became the brand leader in America, a position it maintains today.
- The D'Arcy Masius Benton & Bowles* (DMB&B) advertising agency handled P&G's accounts throughout the 1950s. Its campaigns for *Tide* referred explicitly to P&G because their market research showed that consumers had high levels of confidence in the company.
- Uniquely, DMB&B used print and radio advertising campaigns concurrently in order to quickly build audience familiarity with the brand. Both media forms used the "housewife" character and the ideology that its customers "loved" and "adored" *Tide*.

#### PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media language

##### Historical context:

The post-WWII consumer boom of the 1950s included the rapid development of new technologies for the home, designed to make domestic chores easier. Vacuum cleaners, fridge-freezers, microwave ovens and washing machines all become desirable products for the 1950s consumer. Products linked to these new technologies also developed during this time, for example, washing powder.

##### Cultural context:

Print adverts from the 1950s conventionally used more **copy** than we're used to seeing today. Consumer culture was in its early stages of

development and, with so many 'new' **brands** and products entering markets, potential customers typically needed more information about them than a modern **audience**, more used to **advertising**, **marketing** and **branding**, might need. **Conventions** of print-based advertising are still recognisable in this text however, as detailed below.

#### Consider codes and conventions, and how media language influences meaning:

- Z-line** and a rough **rule of thirds** can be applied to its **composition**.
- Bright, **primary colours** connote the positive associations the producers want the audience to make with the product.
- Headings**, **subheadings** and **slogans** are written in **sans-serif font**, **connoting** an informal **mode of address**.
- This is reinforced with the comic strip style image in the bottom right-hand corner with two women 'talking' about the product using informal **lexis** ("sudsing whizz").
- The more 'technical' details of the product are written in a **serif font**, **connoting** the more 'serious' or 'factual' information that the '1, 2, 3' bullet point list includes.

#### Consider theoretical perspectives:

##### Semiotics – Roland Barthes

- Suspense is created through the **enigma** of "what women want" (**Barthes' Hermeneutic Code**) and emphasised by the tension-building use of multiple exclamation marks (**Barthes' Proairetic Code**).
- Barthes' Semantic Code** could be applied to the use of hearts above the main image. The hearts and the woman's **gesture codes** have **connotations** of love and relationships. It's **connoted** that this is "what women want" (in addition to clean laundry!).
- Hyperbole** and **superlatives** ("Miracle", "World's cleanest wash!", "World's whitest wash!") as well as **tripling** ("No other...") are used to oppose the **connoted** superior cleaning power of *Tide* to its competitors.